

The Eradication of Smallpox

Smallpox was an infectious disease caused by the Variola virus. It killed about 300 million people in the 20th century alone and blinded millions more.

The World Health Organization (WHO) launched an intensified eradication campaign in 1967, led by American epidemiologist Donald Henderson. The campaign used a strategy of surveillance and ring vaccination rather than mass vaccination.

The last naturally occurring case was Ali Maow Maalin, a hospital cook in Merca, Somalia, who became ill on 26 October 1977. He survived. The last death from smallpox was Janet Parker, a medical photographer at the University of Birmingham Medical School, who was infected in August 1978 after the virus escaped from a laboratory.

The WHO declared smallpox eradicated on 8 May 1980. It is the only human disease to have been eradicated. Rinderpest, a disease of cattle, was declared eradicated in 2011.

The variola virus is now held officially at only two locations: the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) in Atlanta, Georgia, and the State Research Center of Virology and Biotechnology (VECTOR) in Koltsovo, Russia.